



sports or activities, which is a good thing. As long as it doesn't involve my hand, my arm, and something that can lead to injuries, he is fine with it," she says.

And that's what she's doing. The violin is a recent addition to her range of interests. She's also been taking classes in *kathak*, as well as lessons in horse riding. She's also become a regular gym-goer. "I think shooting is shooting, but you have to be mentally sound as well. **It's not always going to help you to be (just) physically and technically sound; you have to be mentally balanced too.** So if you are balanced in all three or four ways, if you have a sound mind

and sound body, you will be able to perform a lot better," she says.

That's certainly showing in her scores. At the 2023 Asian Championships in Changwon, where she won a quota in the 25m pistol event, Manu shot a 591 in qualification — her highest score since the 2018 Asian Games. Her consistency over 16 matches in the 10m and 25m pistol events in the space of a month at the Olympic selection trials further added substance to Rana's belief that while she might not have been ready to compete in three events at the Tokyo Games, she certainly is capable of dealing with the same workload in

Paris.

But while her shooting is once more speaking for itself, Manu says she's also learning to not make it her central identity. "I got into shooting when I was 16 years old. Because I was so successful in it at such a young age, I never really got the chance to do anything else. I never really had a childhood away from shooting. "All my interactions and friendships were with other shooters. I had no social life. If I could, I'd go back and tell my 16-year-old self to go out and explore a little. I went to my first World Cup in Rio when I was 16 and after winning gold, I just went back to my hotel room and slept! I